

» CHEQUERED FLAG

No surprises: Verstappen achieved the feat in a race he did not win — he crossed the chequered flag to take fifth place at the Las Vegas Grand Prix — and secured the coveted championship. AP



MAXIMUM CHAMPION

With a **fourth successive** World Drivers' Championship crown, Max Verstappen joins an elite group.

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He was pushed to the limit this year, often finding himself in unfamiliar territory — the back of the grid. But greatness is forged in the fire of adversity, and Max Verstappen rose above all challenges, reaffirming his status as the sport's indisputable champion.

The 2024 Formula One season witnessed a Verstappen who was not as dominant as before. Yet, despite driving a car that didn't obey his every command, he emerged from a tight corner to claim what was rightfully his — a fourth consecutive World Drivers' Championship (WDC) title.

Verstappen, who won as many as 19 of the 22 races last season, had to

fight long and hard with his competitors and his RB20 to notch up nine wins, with the last two coming after a shocking 10-race winless slump. It took time for the Red Bull driver to rediscover his form, stirring debates over his drive and sometimes his demeanour, but he eventually put an end to the doubts and ascended to the throne again.

With a fourth successive WDC crown, Verstappen joins an elite group alongside Juan Manuel Fangio (1954–57), Michael Schumacher (2000–2004), Sebastian Vettel (2010–2013), and his 2021 rival Lewis Hamilton (2017–2020).

But he achieved the feat in a race he did not win — he crossed the chequered flag to take fifth place at the Las Vegas Grand Prix, the first stop of the season-ending triple-header, and secured the

coveted championship.

The illuminated Las Vegas strip, on a Saturday, had F1 cars zipping past for only the second time, with Mercedes' George Russell in control throughout. The weekend belonged to the Silver Arrows, which topped all the sessions and hit the jackpot with a 1–2 finish after unearthing some unbelievable pace. It was Mercedes' turn to take home maximum points, making this the first season to have four different teams secure a top-two finish.

Russell led Hamilton — who bids farewell to the Brackley-based team after a 12-year journey — to the line, with the former taking a dominant victory from pole and the latter delivering a spirited fight through the field. Verstappen, though, didn't look his usual aggressive self, even letting cars go by, except for the orange McLaren of Lando Norris —